

DAG ARCHIVES

from Bengal's ordinary life using a variety of styles. The house that Roy built for himself and his family and moved into in 1950 had achieved almost an iconic status as not only the residence of a living legend but one that was a veritable art gallery open to guests for thriving discussions.

Five decades after Roy's death, DAG (formerly Delhi Art Gallery), a private art company, is endeavouring to revive the vibrant ambience of the house and honour his memory by turning it into a museum dedicated to him. DAG has acquired the house from Roy's descendants and is initiating the renovation process. "We saw the opportunity of making a Jamini Roy museum when we learnt that the Ballygunge house was on the market," says DAG CEO and MD, Ashish Anand. Roy's family was delighted that the house would be turned into a museum. "Caring for such a large house was becoming challenging for us," says Roy's great-granddaughter, Arkamitra Roy. "We had to take the difficult decision of selling it. DAG contacted us. We were overjoyed. It was the best thing that could have happened to Jamini Roy's legacy."

The museum will showcase the artist's vast oeuvre. Roy produced some 20,000 paintings, many of which form integral collections at galleries and museums across the world. Large numbers are also in private collections. As per plans, there will be a memorabilia shop and a café, where visitors can engage in some 'adda'. The DAG "would like to replicate, as far as possible, the spirit of those times and the atmosphere during those days".

The museum would be the country's first privately owned, single-artist museum. The cost of the project as well as the price at which the house was bought from the family is currently confidential, say company sources.

While DAG had obtained the necessary governmental permissions to acquire and set up the museum and negotiations with the family were finalised earlier, it was not until March this year that shifting was completed. According to DAG, "This house is an ideal setting for a museum because it has many interesting nooks and crannies." Mitali Kahali, 70, elder sister of Amitava, narrates an interesting anecdote. "Roy, whom we called Dadu (grandpa), would always add a new section of rooms to the building when their children got married, so each time, there were new corridors and corners. I remember that when an open verandah was constructed, Dida (Roy's wife), who was very beautiful, would come out after a bath and dry her long hair in the sun." Artist Rahul Bose, whose father was close to Roy, remembers Roy always asking the little boy on his birthday what he wanted. "I once told him I wanted a horse and he drew me one. Of course, I had wanted a real one," he chuckles.

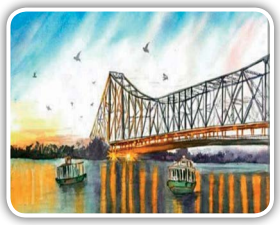
According to DAG, the museum may open its doors to the public in April 2024 on Bengali New Year. ■

Dola Mitra

ART

Another Brush on the Wall

The boundary walls of the **Kolkata Port Trust** lining the Hooghly River are being decorated with depictions of iconic Kolkata scenes







CITYSCAPES (top) paintings of the Howrah Bridge and a tram; (right) the Dakhshineshwar Kali Temple

If you drive down central Kolkata's busy Strand Road that snakes along the Hooghly River, it is unlikely that you will throw a second glance at the walls that separate the river from the road. Pedestrians don't pause to look at it either. "Why would I want to check out these drab walls?" asks Dipen Mukherjee, 30, an IT professional.

Soon, however, it will be arguably impossible to ignore the boundary wall, which stretches for 1.23 km between Millennium Ghat and Babu Ghat, the port that was once, during the British Raj, the key entry point to the city of Kolkata, or Calcutta as it was then known.

The Kolkata Port Trust (Syama Prasad Mookerjee Port Trust) and the Rotary Club of Kolkata have got together to initiate this 'Mega Graffiti Heritage Conservation Project', which aims to revive public interest in this historic location by having the walls painted with graffiti depictions of the city's iconic colonial-era images, including Howrah Bridge, Victoria Memorial, and the tram, among others.

THE PROJECT IS AN ATTEMPT TO SHOWCASE THE HISTORICAL SIGNIFICANCE OF THE RIVER IN CONNECTION WITH THE CITY'S DEVELOPMENT

"The significance of this location cannot be overstated," says Gautam Chakraborti, honorary heritage advisor of KOPT. "It houses all the historic warehouses of the port, which were the important interfaces between land and river during maritime trade." The project is an extension of KOPT's attempt to showcase the historical importance of the river in connection to the city's development. The idea emerged during meetings about the riverfront's beautification.

Per Anand Sharma, honorary secretary of the Rotary Club of Kolkata, many paintings, done by artist Sayon Mondal and team, have already been approved. "It'll take around 30 to 45 days for the project to take off and graffiti to go up, but we are pleased with the way the historical themes have been depicted," he says. ■

Dola Mitra